DIPLOMA PROGRAMME PRACTICE / HL / SET B

Psychology / Paper 3

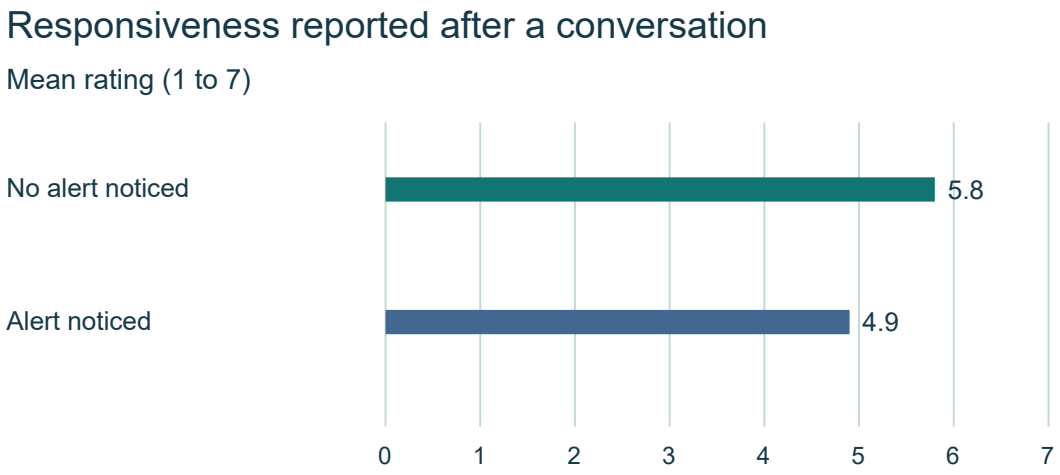
Worked mark scheme · 105 minutes · 30 marks

Answer all four questions. Source 1 appears with Question 1. Use the accompanying resource booklet for Sources 2–5. In Question 4 integrate at least three of Sources 2–5 and your own psychological knowledge.

Judge the whole response against the question-specific markband. Award zero for no creditworthy material. The worked answers illustrate one route; credit other scientifically defensible answers. Class-practical examples are illustrative.

QUESTION 1 / 3 MARKS

Claim for this paper: visible phone notifications during a face-to-face conversation reduce a partner's perceived responsiveness. Source 1. After a café conversation, one member of each adult pair reported noticing either no notifications or at least one. They rated how responsive their partner had seemed. The graph shows the mean rating on a seven-point scale, from 1 (not at all responsive) to 7 (very responsive). The two groups were formed from the reports, not assigned. These research materials are constructed.



Constructed research data.

Explain one issue that limits interpretation of the graph in Source 1.

Worked response. Both the grouping and the outcome depend on one person's retrospective report. Someone who already felt ignored might notice or remember a screen lighting up more readily. This could place more dissatisfied respondents in the “noticed” group and lower its mean even without a causal effect of the alert. The graph shows an association with reported noticing.

Other valid route. Conversation topic, prior relationship or another relevant group difference could affect the ratings. Alternatively, the absence of any display of spread limits conclusions about individual pairs. Develop one limitation with a specific implication for these means.

Markband. 1: identify a relevant limitation. 2: describe it clearly in relation to the graph. 3: explain precisely which interpretation it limits and why.

QUESTION 2 / 6 MARKS

Analyse the findings from Source 2 and state a conclusion about whether visible notifications reduce perceived responsiveness.

Worked response. With visible notifications the mean rating was 4.6 versus 5.4 with the same lit screen displaying a neutral pattern. The mean difference, notification minus neutral, was −0.8 scale points. The reported 95% interval of −1.33 to −0.27 is consistent with a lower average rating in the notification condition. It does not mean every listener felt less understood or that behaviour declined by 0.8 points.

Conclusion bounded by design. Assignment was random at the level of the pair and only one rating per pair contributed, so partners in one conversation were not counted as independent observations. Both displays lit at the same times. The contrast therefore concerns the social meaning of notification cues beyond the matched light change. A single scripted conversation among strangers provides limited evidence about close friends or ongoing relationships.

Markband. 1–2: limited or inaccurate reading and a weak conclusion. 3–4: mostly accurate analysis uses some relevant findings and relates a conclusion to the claim. 5–6: detailed, accurate analysis supports a conclusion closely matched to the claim and the evidence.

QUESTION 3 / 6 MARKS

To what extent are the findings in Source 3 transferable to other people or conversational settings?

Worked response. The idea that an unexplained alert signals divided attention may transfer to informal conversations where undivided attention is similarly expected. Detailed accounts of the relationship, purpose of the meeting and understanding of the phone rule would help a reader assess that similarity. Two participants who explained a caring responsibility already illustrate a boundary: the same alert could be interpreted as necessary rather than dismissive.

Limits and judgement. The participants were co-workers from a single service team who volunteered after adopting a phone agreement. Their shared norms and job demands may differ from those of unfamiliar partners or families. Recruiting contrasting contexts and reporting disconfirming accounts would show whether the interpretation travels. Neither the small sample nor agreement among participants justifies a population percentage. Transfer is plausible for a mechanism under similar norms, less certain elsewhere.

Markband. 1–2: a relevant qualitative research consideration is recognised but little applied. 3–4: relevant discussion applies it to some features of the source. 5–6: a detailed, accurate discussion uses the particular participants, procedure or accounts to explain its implications.

QUESTION 4 / 15 MARKS

To what extent can we conclude that visible notifications reduce a conversation partner's perceived responsiveness? Use your own knowledge of the role of technology and at least three of Sources 2–5.

Worked synthesis. Source 2 separates the meaning of a notification from an equally timed neutral light and shows a 0.8-point reduction in perceived responsiveness. Attentional capture could interrupt listening; alternatively the partner could interpret the cue as a signal of competing social priorities even if the speaker continues listening. A rating of feeling understood is relevant to interpersonal communication, but it does not identify which process occurred.

Connecting sources. Source 3 explains why an identical event might mean something different when a caring obligation is understood. Source 4 distinguishes observed checking from visibility: interruption occurred in 12/30 conversations with a checked alert, 4/25 with an ignored alert and 3/25 without a visible alert. These natural observations suggest that inspecting a message may matter; conversations that were already less engaging could also invite checking. A pause defined by an observer is not identical to a listener's appraisal.

Conditional judgement. Source 5 varies both the alert and the prior explanation. The rating deficit relative to the matched no-alert condition is 1.0 point without an agreed reason but only 0.1 with one. These are descriptive means; uncertainty about the difference between those gaps is unknown. The convergence supports a conditional effect on perception in brief interactions, particularly when competing demands are unexplained. It gives weaker support for a universal effect, for actual listening deficits, or for permanent harm to a relationship. Credit equally coherent syntheses drawing on at least three permitted sources.

Markband. 1–3: fragmented knowledge with limited use of the claim or evidence. 4–6: mainly descriptive reference to the sources. 7–9: relevant evidence and knowledge partly support a conclusion, with uneven integration. 10–12: developed critical analysis combines sources and relevant extension knowledge. 13–15: a coherent synthesis of at least three permitted sources weighs agreement, tensions and limits, uses psychological knowledge precisely and reaches a supported conclusion.